principle in ***Jainism***, which takes non-violence to the extremes, regarding even the unintentional killing of an insect as a defect.

Although the principle of non-violence is sometimes upheld as a moral universal, this actually runs counter to traditional orthodoxy that understands the *Vedic* ***dharma***-prescriptions as different for each caste and station of life (***ashrama***). They are not reducible to a single basic principle. In fact, the ***dharma***-rules approve certain acts of killing, specifically in the context of sacrificial rituals. Moreover, fighting and killing are included in the caste-duties of *Kshatriya* warriors.

Considerations of pleasure and pain are irrelevant to the determination of what is right and wrong: the only source of knowledge about ***dharma***-values are the injunctions and prohibitions found in the eternal and infallible Vedic revelation. Non-Vedic considerations such as pleasure and pain or the promptings of individual conscience are irrelevant. While orthodoxy forbids certain acts of killing and injuring, such prohibitions cannot be universalised since they are relative to a context of action. From, 'It is wrong to kill Brahmins' one cannot infer the general proposition, 'It is wrong to kill'. Killing that is prescribed as a part of a ritual and which is performed in a spirit of 'duty for duty's sake' will not have negative consequences for the agent. In short, the ***Veda*** as the supreme source of values, cannot itself be evaluated by extra-Vedic considerations.

Further reading: Halbfass 1991; O'Flaherty 1991

Akasha (atmosphere, ether): according to ***Vaisheshika***, a type of basic substance (***dravya***). It is the vehicle of sounds, unitary, present wherever there are physical objects, eternal in that it lacks beginning and end, and imperceptible.